ECHOBOUND

The World Remembers You.



Alder Hollow and the first crossing

Product Strategy and Game Design

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A story-driven adventure about rebuilding connections in a fictional Indian Himalayan valley. Player decisions shape the places they restore, the people they meet and the opportunities they discover when they return.

Development stage: product definition and pre-production. Illustrations establish the proposed visual direction; they are not screenshots from a playable build.

Product decision

I am defining ECHOBOUND as a premium, single-player PC adventure in which restoration decisions leave persistent changes in the world. The first development investment is one complete chapter that proves this experience before production expands.

The player becomes a Waykeeper in a fractured valley. Recovering a scarce component creates a practical choice: reconnect an isolated outpost or restore the workshop that can support future repairs. Returning to the settlement reveals what that commitment changed.

Purpose of this document

This document establishes the product direction, first playable scope, experience requirements, consequence system, research programme, commercial assumptions and delivery gates. It is intended to guide implementation and review by design, engineering, narrative, art and production contributors.

Development status

Product definition and pre-production. Research activities, playtests, pricing and commercial measures below are planned work or explicitly stated assumptions. No completed player study, released build, sales result or validated market claim is represented here.

The product promise

When I return to a place, I should recognise the difference my actions made. Every major decision must connect to a visible change, an informed character response and a meaningful opportunity.

01 Product strategy

The player need

My starting hypothesis is that players who value narrative agency want a clearer connection between a decision and its lasting effect. A brief dialogue acknowledgement may be insufficient; an unexplained penalty may feel arbitrary. ECHOBOUND will test whether visible local consequences create attachment without requiring a large branching world.

Audience and positioning

The primary audience is PC players who enjoy atmospheric exploration, environmental puzzles and character relationships. They should value a deliberate pace and returning to familiar locations. The secondary audience enjoys restoration and light resource decisions but does not want a complex management simulation.

The proposed position is an authored adventure about responsibility for places. The product will compete for attention through readable consequences and a coherent setting. I will validate that position against player interviews and a documented comparison of relevant games before committing to full production.

Product boundaries

Single-player comes first. Cooperative play remains a later hypothesis because shared decisions, host ownership, disconnects and progression synchronisation change the product substantially. Combat, unrestricted construction, procedural worlds and generated dialogue are outside the first chapter.

Principle	Implementation consequence
Visible memory	Major decisions alter a place, response and opportunity.
Fair choices	Disclose immediate costs and what remains unresolved.
Specific relationships	Characters refer to actions they can plausibly know.
Recoverable outcomes	Preserve a path forward after an undesirable choice.
Controlled scope	Prove one complete consequence loop before expansion.

Conditions for reconsidering the concept

If players understand the choice but remain indifferent to its aftermath, I will revisit the emotional stakes and restoration payoff. If repeated tests still show little interest, production should stop or change direction before more locations are commissioned.

02 World and first chapter



Character direction from left to right: the Waykeeper, Mira, Tovan and Eren.

The valley after the Silence

The Silence disrupted the valley's signal towers and isolated its settlements. Routes deteriorated and communities began protecting their remaining resources. The Waykeeper restores connections through exploration, repair and negotiated priorities. The opening communicates this through practical needs rather than a long history lesson.

The First Crossing

The first chapter contains Alder Hollow, a damaged crossing, a closed workshop and an abandoned signal station. Mira maintains the crossing; Tovan runs the workshop; Eren carries messages between settlements. Each character has a practical need and a different view of recovery.

Mira needs a regulator to reopen the supply route to an outpost. Tovan needs the same component to restart machinery for replacement fittings. The player retrieves one working regulator from the signal station. Both uses are valid; the chapter permits one immediate restoration.

Branch	Immediate result	Unresolved need
Crossing first	Bridge opens; outpost route and its residents become accessible.	Workshop remains closed during this chapter.
Workshop first	Machinery runs; a repair tool enables an alternate local activity.	Outpost remains disconnected during this chapter.

Narrative contract

The decision concerns which project happens first. The interface must not imply permanent destruction of the unchosen project. Later recovery is a proposed continuation, not a feature promised by the chapter. Both branches reconnect at a common ending while preserving distinct world states.

Example dialogue

Before the choice, Mira says: "The outpost still has stores. What they need is a road that stays open." Tovan answers: "Give me a working regulator and I can make the fittings we keep searching for." These lines communicate competing priorities without assigning moral labels.

After workshop restoration, Mira acknowledges the actual outcome: "I heard the machinery. That will help us. The crossing still needs an answer." Dialogue remains conditional, concise and consistent with what each character knows.

03 Gameplay and progression

The core loop

Discover a need, investigate its context, explore for a solution, make a commitment, complete the work and return to experience its consequence. Each loop must provide immediate closure and an unresolved connection to the wider valley.

Movement and interaction

The initial interaction vocabulary is move, look, inspect, speak, collect and use a tool at an authored location. Objects display a contextual action only within valid range. The prototype will test camera comfort, interaction reach and whether prompts remain readable against the environment.

Exploration challenge

The signal station uses a contained environmental puzzle: inspect the mechanism, trace its disconnected linkage, recover a handle and operate the release in the correct physical location. The challenge teaches observation and tool use. Repeated failure must not consume the regulator or lock the chapter.

Progression model

Progression is based on access, tools and relationships. The crossing branch opens a route. The workshop branch unlocks a fitting tool and a local restoration activity. Neither grants a universal advantage score. The first chapter avoids currency, skill trees and repeatable resource grinding.

Feedback and pacing

Important interactions receive an immediate visual or audio response and a journal update where necessary. After restoration, the player regains control and can inspect the changed space. A short scene may establish the result, but it must not replace exploration of the consequence.

Moment	Player question	Design response
Arrival	Where should I go?	One visible local need and an optional contextual prompt.
Investigation	Why do both people need this?	Short conversations and inspectable environmental evidence.
Commitment	What am I choosing now?	Immediate outcomes, resource cost and unresolved need.
Return	What difference did I make?	Changed environment, valid dialogue and new access.

04 Persistent world specification

The Echo system

An Echo is a recorded action that drives authored responses. The initial system will use deterministic conditions rather than unrestricted generated narrative. World truth, character knowledge and presentation are separate so a character does not react to an event simply because it exists in the save file.

Field	Example or rule
event_id	Unique stable identifier for the committed event.
event_type	RESTORATION_COMPLETED with target CROSSING or WORKSHOP.
chapter_id	FIRST_CROSSING; controls content and migration context.
state_version	Version of the persistent data schema.
knowledge_flags	Which characters have witnessed or learned the event.
consequence_flags	Access, environment and dialogue conditions derived from state.

State transition

The chapter begins with regulator ownership false and restoration NONE. Retrieving the regulator changes ownership to true. Confirming either project checks ownership, valid quest state and an unset restoration. Completion consumes the regulator and commits CROSSING or WORKSHOP. The alternative cannot also complete during this chapter.

The commit must be idempotent: retrying the same event must not consume another resource or award another outcome. Save data is written through a temporary file and validated before replacing the last valid save. A backup supports recovery from interrupted writes.

Consistency and recovery

World visuals are reconstructed from committed state after loading. Dialogue conditions read the same authoritative state. If a cosmetic response fails, progression remains available. A missing mandatory asset or corrupted state produces a clear recovery path instead of silently advancing into an invalid branch.

Test coverage

Test both branches with save/load before commitment, after commitment and after consequence discovery. Repeat interactions, interrupted saves and replayed event requests must not duplicate rewards or create contradictory routes. Unknown future save versions must be handled explicitly rather than overwritten.

05 Player experience and screens

First session journey

The player configures essential settings, arrives near Alder Hollow, encounters the blocked crossing and learns the workshop need. Exploration leads to the regulator. Returning opens the comparison flow, followed by an explicit commitment and restoration activity. The chapter closes only after the consequence can be encountered.

Screen	Information and behaviour
Start and settings	Continue, new game and settings; subtitles and input options available before play.

Screen	Information and behaviour
Exploration HUD	Contextual interaction, active tool and optional objective; no permanent relationship meter.
Journal	Needs, accepted commitments and observed outcomes; hidden information remains hidden.
Valley map	Discovered locations and accessible routes; distinguish unknown from blocked.
Restoration decision	Both immediate outcomes, regulator cost and remaining need; confirm or return.
Echo history	Important completed events and consequences the player has actually discovered.
Save menu	Slot, chapter, branch where known, timestamp and overwrite confirmation.

Decision interaction

The comparison presents Crossing and Workshop as equally selectable options. Focus changes reveal details without committing. Confirmation names the selected project and states that the regulator will be used. Cancel returns to the comparison with focus preserved. A second confirmation is unnecessary after the explicit commitment.

Interface language

Use specific instructions: “Use the regulator at the workshop” and “The crossing remains closed.” Avoid vague labels such as “Accept destiny” for an irreversible action. The journal distinguishes promises from suggestions so optional conversation cannot accidentally become a binding commitment.

Accessibility and presentation

Use strong silhouettes, readable interaction targets and environmental sound to establish restoration. Do not rely on colour alone. Support remappable controls, controller focus, adjustable text, subtitles, reduced camera shake and alternatives to repeated presses. Each setting requires verification inside gameplay and menus.

06 Requirements and acceptance

The first playable chapter is an implementation milestone. Its acceptance conditions describe behaviour that design and engineering can verify together.

ID	Requirement	Acceptance condition
R01	Learn the competing needs	Both needs can be discovered before commitment; journal does not select a winner.
R02	Recover the regulator	Valid completion grants exactly one regulator and persists after reload.
R03	Commit to one restoration	Only one branch commits; confirmation identifies cost and immediate outcome.

ID	Requirement	Acceptance condition
R04	Experience consequences	Chosen branch changes environment, dialogue and access consistently.
R05	Preserve knowledge	Characters respond only when their authored knowledge conditions are satisfied.
R06	Resume progress	Reload reproduces branch state and inventory without duplicated events.
R07	Navigate without a mouse	All essential menus and decisions support controller focus and activation.
R08	Recover from errors	Failed save preserves a valid prior save and communicates the failure.

Priority and scope control

R01 through R08 are required. Extra locations, combat, crafting economies, cooperative networking, voice generation and cosmetic commerce are deferred. A requested feature enters the chapter only if it resolves a demonstrated failure of the core loop or an essential access requirement.

Quality targets

The intended performance target is stable 30 frames per second at the agreed minimum PC configuration, with higher settings considered later. This target remains provisional until reference hardware is selected and the technical prototype is profiled. Loading and memory budgets will be measured rather than invented.

Defect policy

No known progression blocker, destructive save defect or contradictory main branch can remain open at external playtest readiness. Lower-severity visual and optional dialogue issues may remain only with documented impact, ownership and a planned resolution.

07 Discovery and validation

Research questions

I will investigate what makes a game choice memorable, how players recognise consequences and what information makes a commitment feel fair. The initial plan is eight qualitative interviews followed by iterative formative playtests. These samples reveal issues and themes; they do not estimate market demand.

Interview approach

Recruit adults who have recently played relevant exploration or narrative games, including different levels of familiarity. Ask about an actual memorable decision, a misunderstood outcome, reasons for revisiting locations and reasons for abandoning a game. Record consent, minimise identifying information and separate verbatim statements from my interpretation.

Playable protocol

Ask participants to play the chapter without coaching. Before commitment, invite them to explain the two immediate outcomes. After returning, ask what changed and what they believe caused it. Observe interaction failures, uncertainty, spontaneous exploration and whether they choose to inspect the affected location.

Hypothesis	Evidence	Revision trigger
The choice is readable	Participant explains both immediate outcomes.	Two of five formative participants misunderstand a material consequence.
Memory is visible	Participant identifies the main world change.	Two of five miss or misattribute the main change.
The aftermath matters	Unprompted return behaviour and explanation of interest.	Players notice change but repeatedly describe it as inconsequential.
Progress feels reliable	Branch/save test results and observed blockers.	Any reproducible destructive or progression-blocking defect.

Iteration decisions

Repeated misunderstanding calls for information or interaction changes. Correct understanding with low interest calls for revisiting stakes and payoff. More tutorial text will not automatically solve low motivation. Every revision will link an observed issue to a hypothesis and a subsequent test.

Market investigation

Before full production, document relevant released games using current store pages, developer material and direct gameplay inspection. Compare consequence visibility, scope, audience response and commercial positioning. No competitor gap or uniqueness claim is established by this document.

08 Metrics and commercial model

Primary experience measure

Meaningful return rate is the number of players who complete a restoration and subsequently encounter its authored consequence, divided by players who complete a restoration in the same chapter cohort. It measures exposure to the product loop, not emotional meaning; interviews supply that interpretation.

Event	Trigger and essential properties
chapter_started	New chapter instance; anonymous session and build version.
regulator_recovered	Validated acquisition; chapter instance.
restoration_committed	Successful commit; selected branch and elapsed session time.

Event	Trigger and essential properties
consequence_encountered	Player enters the authored consequence trigger; branch and consequence ID.
chapter_completed	Common chapter ending reached; branch and completion state.
save_failed	Write or validation failure; non-sensitive error category.

Deduplicate milestone events within a chapter instance. Separate restarts from new participants, record the build version and define the analysis window before reading results. Use aggregate telemetry with appropriate disclosure and controls; do not collect raw conversations or unnecessary personal information.

Business model

The initial hypothesis is a premium PC game with a complete base experience. Narrative expansions are a later option. Paid progression advantages, randomised purchases and a live-service content obligation are excluded from the initial model. Price and regional offers remain subject to research and platform terms.

Illustrative break even scenario

For planning only, assume recoverable development and launch costs of INR 30,00,000 and net contribution of INR 500 per paid copy after all relevant deductions and variable costs. Break even would require 6,000 copies. At INR 350 contribution it would require 8,572 copies, rounded up; at INR 650 it would require 4,616 copies. These are arithmetic scenarios, not a budget, forecast or validated selling price.

A production funding decision requires actual staffing estimates, asset and audio quotations, testing costs, marketing plans, contingency and the applicable platform and tax treatment. Gross store price must never be substituted for net contribution.

09 Delivery roadmap and ownership

Gate	Deliverable	Decision
Discovery	Interviews, audience definition and comparable-game review.	Does evidence support the problem and positioning?
Interaction prototype	Complete storyboard and clickable decision flow.	Can players understand the intended choice?
Technical prototype	One event drives environment, dialogue and access through save/load.	Is persistent state dependable?
First playable	Both branches work from arrival to return.	Does the core experience merit refinement?
Vertical slice	Representative art, audio, interface and performance.	Can the team sustain the quality at a viable cost?

Gate	Deliverable	Decision
Production approval	Costed scope, staffing, schedule and risk allowance.	Fund, revise or stop before expansion.

Sequencing and dependencies

State modelling and narrative branch definitions precede full dialogue implementation. Greybox locations precede final environment art. The save prototype precedes content expansion. Accessibility and instrumentation begin during the playable build rather than being added only before launch.

My responsibilities

I own the product definition, research plan, prioritisation, player journeys, interface specifications, acceptance criteria and decision log. A game designer owns moment-to-moment challenge tuning with me. Engineering owns implementation and technical validation; narrative, art, animation, audio and QA each require explicit capacity.

Planning discipline

Calendar commitments will follow team availability and measured prototype throughput. Every gate requires an owner, an evidence package and a decision. Review milestones against outcomes, not the number of screens or assets completed. Record scope changes with their cost, dependency and learning value.

Launch approach

Use a private test to establish reliability, then a controlled public demo when onboarding and consequence comprehension pass review. Prepare accurate gameplay footage and a store description that reflects implemented features. Full launch requires production content, support capacity, compatibility testing and a costed release plan. No public release date is committed here.

10 Risks and execution backlog

Risk	Control
Branching content grows too quickly	Keep consequences local and reconnect branches to a shared chapter structure.
Players miss the payoff	Combine physical change, informed dialogue and changed opportunity.
State becomes contradictory	Use one authoritative state model and branch/save regression coverage.
Ambition exceeds capacity	Protect the chapter boundary and defer networking and generated dialogue.
Restoration feels repetitive	Test interaction variety before commissioning more locations.
Performance degrades	Profile representative assets on agreed reference hardware early.

First execution backlog

Order	Work item	Completion evidence
1	Define branch states and knowledge rules	State diagram and invalid-transition list reviewed.
2	Storyboard arrival through return	Both paths connect to a complete ending.
3	Prepare research recruitment	Screening, consent and interview guide ready.
4	Prototype the decision interface	Immediate costs and outcomes can be explained.
5	Build the persistent event prototype	Both branches survive save/load checks.
6	Greybox the chapter	Exploration and restoration work end to end.
7	Run formative playtests	Observations, issues and revision decisions recorded.

Release readiness

Before a commercial release, confirm content completeness, supported hardware, save recovery, accessibility coverage, privacy disclosures, age-rating requirements, asset rights, store materials, crash reporting and support ownership. These are launch work items; completion is not implied by this product document.

Approval basis

The immediate investment is a reliable first chapter. Expansion is justified only when players understand the decision, notice the world response and show a reason to continue. ECHOBOUND earns its ambition by making one place remember accurately before asking players to care about an entire valley.